

Chad



Landlocked in north-central Africa, Chad has had a turbulent history since independence from France in 1960. Intermittent periods of civil war followed a military coup in 1975.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Mostly plateaus sloping west-ward to Lake Chad. Northern third is Sahara. Tibesti Mountains in north rise to 10,826 ft (3300 m).

CLIMATE

Three distinct zones: desert in north, semiarid region in center, and tropics in south.

PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Half the population live in the southern fifth of Chad. The northern third has only 100,000 people, mainly Muslim Touhou nomads. Democracy was restored in 1996 by ex-coup leader Idriss Déby. Instability has continued, first with tension between Muslims and southern Christians and, more recently, with rebellions in the east.



INSIGHT: Lake Chad is slowly drying up – it is now estimated to be just 10% of the size it was in 1970

**THE ECONOMY**

The discovery of oil, and the opening of a pipeline to the coast via Cameroon, are transforming Chad's economy, though the new wealth is unlikely to reach most people.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Chad

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: N'djamena

POPULATION: 11.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 495,752 sq. miles
(1,284,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 23 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: French*, Sara, Arabic*, Maba
RELIGIONS: Muslim 55%, traditional beliefs 35%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Other 30%, Sara 28%, Mayo-Kebbi 12%, Arab 12%, Ouaddai 9%, Kanem-Bornou 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes